

Away from the edge: On waste disposal from the 1984 Bhopal plant accident

The **incineration** of toxic waste from the Bhopal **tragedy** **took** time and effort

The Madhya Pradesh Pollution Control Board has confirmed that officials had **incinerated** 337 tonnes of toxic waste moved to a private waste treatment facility in Pithampur from the **defunct** Union Carbide facility in Bhopal. The event closes a single, but important, chapter in the **sordid** history of the 1984 Bhopal disaster, the state response to which **pushed** the city and its people **to the edge**. The successful incineration is **illustrative** in that it demanded **interventions** from the Madhya Pradesh High Court, the Supreme Court of India, and the Union Environment Ministry, among other **stakeholders**, over more than a **decade**. In the end, the State government was able to arrange for the waste to be safely **disposed of** — including an **outreach** exercise to **assuage** public **anxiety** over the **emissions** — within six months at a cost of ₹126 crore. **Evidently** the means have always existed; the political **initiative** to **effect** them **has** been **wanting**. This is an important detail: **waste**, once it has entered the environment, **has** a **tendency** to be converted to different forms; it **seldom** goes away. The toxic waste incinerated thus far has **yielded** more than 800 tonnes of **ash** and **residue** that officials will have to **landfill** in a scientific manner. Like solid waste landfills around the country, this new facility will require regular **upkeep**, **monitoring**, and funds of its own. The **site** of the Union Carbide plant also **retains** several more tonnes of **contaminated** soil and other **hazardous artefacts**, plus contaminated subsurface resources in the area.

Crucially, **much** of the **impetus** for positive change in the matter, including waste removal, **has** come from victims' families, survivors, and **activists** rather than from the state. Survivors' groups have filed **petitions** arguing that deaths and injuries continue to be **undercounted** and that they are owed inflation-adjusted damages. Since the Supreme Court **closed the door** on the **curative** route, also in dispute is whether a new valuation of losses can be forced on The Dow Chemical Company, **notwithstanding** the fact that it remains a **proclaimed offender**. Long-term **surveillance** has been **patchy**, with activists and survivors **alleging** that the advisory **committee** appointed by the top court **has** met only **sporadically** and that local hospitals continue to suffer a shortage of specialist medical workers to **attend to** survivors. In the final analysis, Dow must **account for** all **remediation** activities. Both the State and the Centre must close pending settlement claims and attend on a self-motivated basis to the survivors' **well-being**, if required with the **assistance** of a new **statutory** body to **unify** health, relief, and remediation goals. **Ultimately**, the families must be able to move on.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

[Practice Exercise]

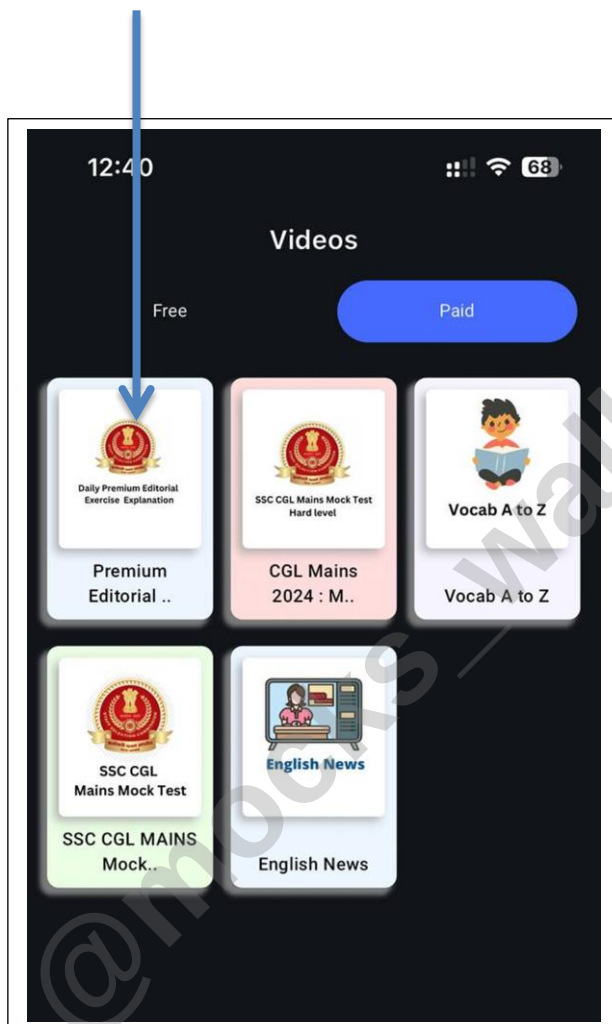
Vocabulary

1. **Waste disposal** (noun) – It refers to the processes involved in managing and discarding unwanted materials, encompassing collection, treatment, and final disposal methods कचरा निपटान
2. **Incineration** (noun) – Burning, combustion, cremation, fire disposal, thermal destruction दहन
3. **Tragedy** (noun) – Disaster, catastrophe, calamity, misfortune, sorrow त्रासदी
4. **Incinerate** (verb) – Burn, cremate, combust, reduce to ashes, torch जलाना
5. **Defunct** (adjective) – Obsolete, inactive, extinct, non-functional, dead समाप्त
6. **Sordid** (adjective) – Dirty, filthy, disgraceful, shameful, vile गंदा/घिनौना
7. **Push to the edge** (phrase) – Drive to extreme, force to limit, bring to brink, press to desperation, provoke to collapse हद तक पहुँचाना
8. **Illustrative** (adjective) – Demonstrative, explanatory, descriptive, revealing, clarifying व्याख्यात्मक
9. **Intervention** (noun) – Involvement, interference, mediation, action, participation हस्तक्षेप
10. **Stakeholder** (noun) – Participant, interested party, contributor, partner, collaborator हितधारक
11. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years, दशक
12. **Dispose** (of) (verb) – Discard, get rid of, eliminate, dump, clear हटाना
13. **Outreach** (noun) – Communication, engagement, extension, contact, connection पहुँच
14. **Assuage** (verb) – Ease, calm, soothe, allay, pacify शांत करना
15. **Anxiety** (noun) – Worry, fear, nervousness, apprehension, unease चिंता
16. **Emission** (noun) – Discharge, release, outflow, exhalation, expulsion उत्सर्जन
17. **Evidently** (adverb) – Clearly, obviously, plainly, apparently, manifestly स्पष्टतः
18. **Effect** (verb) – Bring about, accomplish, cause, implement, execute कार्यान्वित करना
19. **Wanting** (adjective) – Lacking, deficient, missing, incomplete, inadequate कमी
20. **Tendency** (noun) – Inclination, propensity, habit, predisposition, trend प्रवृत्ति

21. **Seldom** (adverb) – Rarely, infrequently, hardly ever, sporadically, occasionally
शायद ही कभी
22. **Yield** (verb) – Produce, generate, give, result in, provide उत्पन्न करना
23. **Ash** (noun) – Cinder, residue, remains, powder, soot राख
24. **Residue** (noun) – Remnant, leftover, remainder, deposit, rest अवशेष
25. **Landfill** (verb) – Dump, bury, dispose in ground, cover with earth, fill landfill गाड़ना
26. **Upkeep** (noun) – Maintenance, care, servicing, preservation, sustenance रखरखाव
27. **Monitoring** (noun) – Observation, supervision, tracking, checking, oversight निगरानी
28. **Contaminated** (adjective) – Polluted, tainted, infected, fouled, spoiled प्रदूषित
29. **Hazardous** (adjective) – Dangerous, risky, unsafe, perilous, harmful खतरनाक
30. **Artefact** (noun) – Object, item, relic, piece, remnant वस्तु
31. **Impetus** (noun) – Motivation, drive, stimulus, encouragement, inspiration प्रोत्साहन
32. **Activist** (noun) – Campaigner, advocate, reformer, protester, supporter कार्यकर्ता
33. **Petition** (noun) – Appeal, request, plea, application, entreaty याचिका
34. **Undercount** (verb) – Undervalue, underestimate, downplay, miscount, minimize कम गिनना
35. **Closed the door** (phrase) – Shut off opportunity, refuse option, end possibility, bar route, finish path मौका बंद करना
36. **Curative** (adjective) – Healing, remedial, therapeutic, restorative, medicinal उपचारात्मक
37. **Notwithstanding** (preposition) – Despite, in spite of, even with, regardless of, although बावजूद
38. **Proclaimed** (adjective) – Declared, announced, pronounced, stated, affirmed घोषित
39. **Offender** (noun) – Criminal, wrongdoer, lawbreaker, culprit, violator अपराधी
40. **Surveillance** (noun) – Observation, monitoring, watch, scrutiny, supervision निगरानी
41. **Patchy** (adjective) – Irregular, inconsistent, uneven, sporadic, scattered असंगत
42. **Allege** (verb) – Claim, assert, charge, accuse, contend आरोप लगाना
43. **Sporadically** (adverb) – Occasionally, irregularly, intermittently, infrequently, inconsistently छिटपुट रूप से

44. **Attend** (to) (verb) – Care for, look after, address, deal with, handle ध्यान देना
45. **Account for** (phrasal verb) – Explain, justify, take responsibility for, clarify, report के लिए जिम्मेदार होना
46. **Remediation** (noun) – Rectification, correction, repair, redress, cleanup सुधार
47. **Well-being** (noun) – Welfare, health, happiness, prosperity, comfort भलाई
48. **Assistance** (noun) – Help, support, aid, backing, cooperation सहायता
49. **Statutory** (adjective) – Legal, mandated, authorized, legislated, official वैधानिक
50. **Unify** (verb) – Unite, merge, combine, integrate, consolidate एक करना
51. **Ultimately** (adverb) – Finally, eventually, in the end, conclusively, after all अंततः

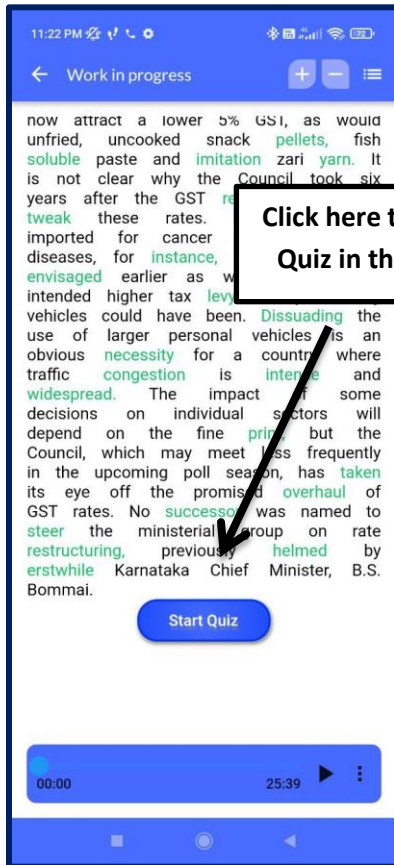
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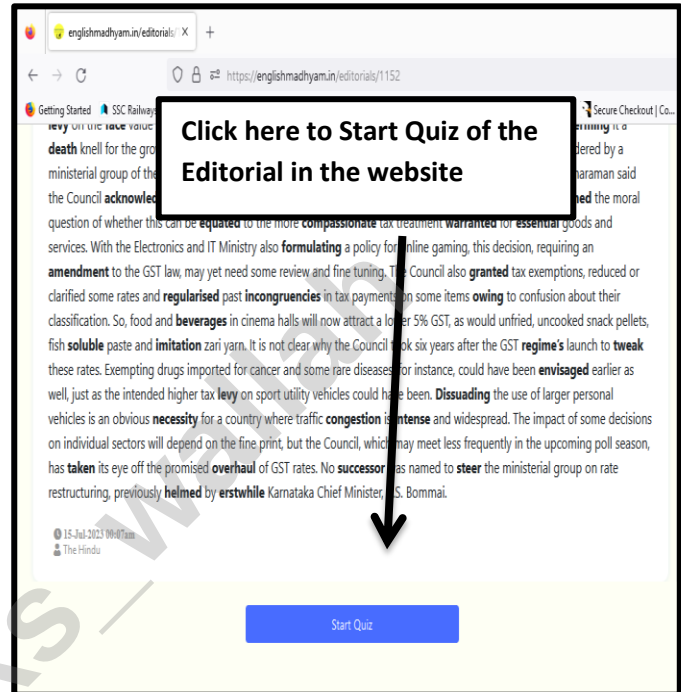
Summary of the Editorial

1. The Madhya Pradesh Pollution Control Board confirmed the incineration of 337 tonnes of toxic waste from the Bhopal disaster.
2. This waste was moved to a private waste treatment facility in Pithampur from the abandoned Union Carbide plant.
3. The successful incineration marks the closure of one chapter in the long and painful aftermath of the 1984 Bhopal tragedy.
4. Achieving this disposal required interventions from the Madhya Pradesh High Court, the Supreme Court, and the Union Environment Ministry.
5. The final disposal took six months and cost ₹126 crore.
6. The delay wasn't due to technical impossibility but a lack of political initiative.
7. Toxic waste in the environment tends to persist or transform; it rarely disappears without proper disposal.
8. Incineration produced over 800 tonnes of ash and residue, which now require scientific landfill management.
9. The landfill will need regular upkeep, monitoring, and dedicated funds, similar to other solid waste landfills in India.
10. The Union Carbide site still contains contaminated soil, hazardous materials, and polluted subsurface resources.
11. Much of the progress on waste removal was driven by survivors, victims' families, and activists, not the government.
12. Survivors' groups continue to argue that deaths and injuries are underreported and demand inflation-adjusted compensation.
13. Since the Supreme Court closed the curative petition route, there's a dispute over reassessing damages from Dow Chemical, the proclaimed offender.
14. Long-term health surveillance of survivors has been inadequate, with poor advisory committee functioning and shortages of specialist doctors in local hospitals.
15. Dow must be held accountable for all remediation, and both State and Centre should proactively resolve pending settlement claims, possibly with a new statutory body to ensure survivors' health and welfare.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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